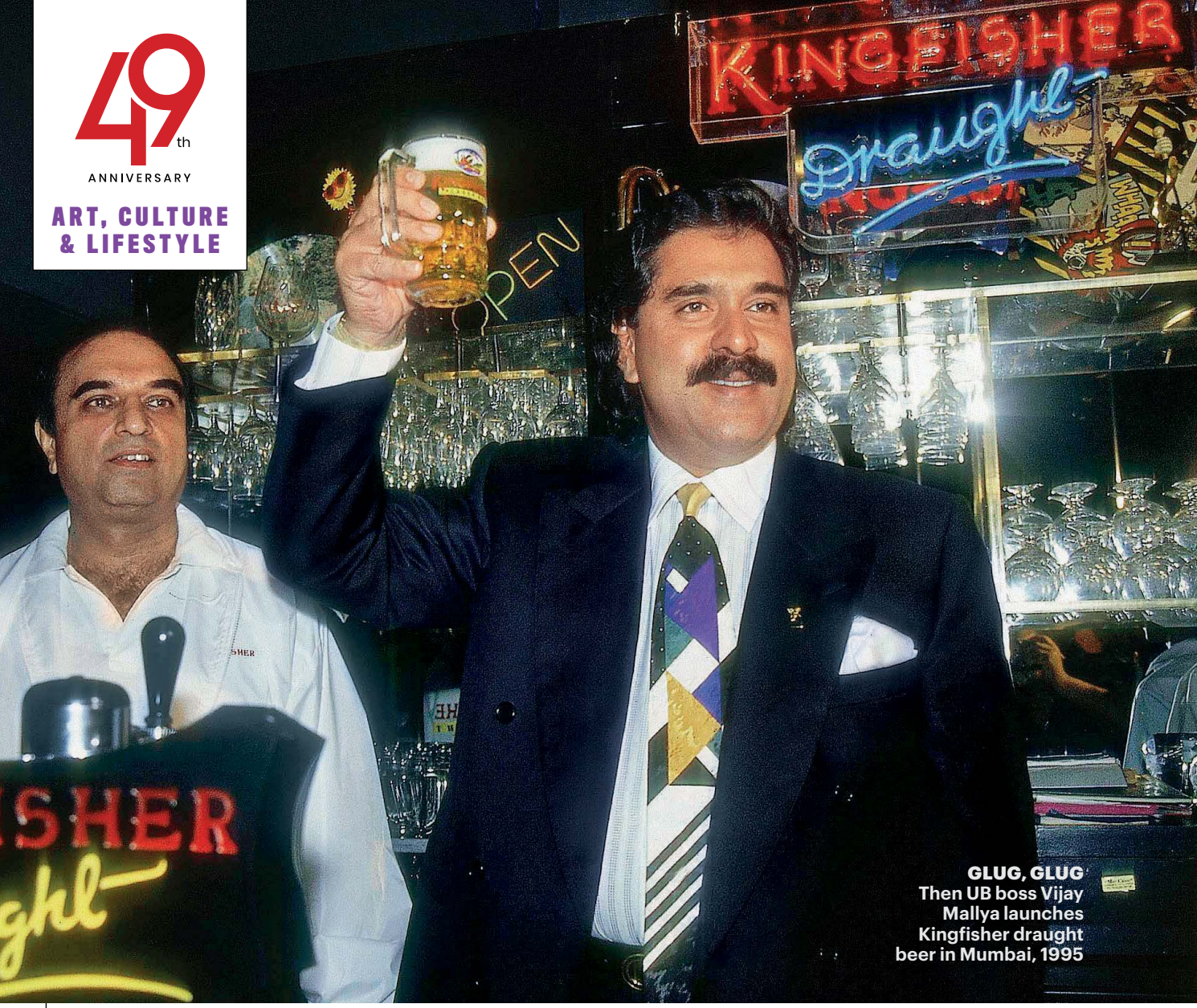


GLUG, GLUG Then UB boss Vijay Mallya launches Kingfisher draught beer in Mumbai, 1995

ASHESH SHAH

THE BEER BOOM

ENTER THE PUB HOPPERS

UB's Kingfisher made beer cool and aspirational in the 1990s. The heady days have not stopped since for the domestic alcobev industry

BY AJAY SUKUMARAN

"O la la la la leyo!" Advertisement jingles couldn't get any catchier than this Caribbean calypso tune from 1996, aired during the biggest sporting event in the country that year—the cricket World Cup. It was the theme that Kingfisher Premium, India's top-selling beer, tapped into—with canny surrogate advertising—to establish itself as a cool, stylish, aspirational brand at a time when the beer biggies of the world were eyeing the Indian market.

The Kingfisher label itself was new beer in old bottles, so to speak, because it had been around since 1857. Owned by United Breweries (UB), the credit for digging out this defunct label from the company archives and relaunching it in 1978 goes to Vijay Mallya, then a 23-year-old doing a mentorship detail at the beer company run by his father. In that sense, it was a brand